

Handy pointers

- To view a StarImpress presentation, you don't need to start the entire application; Starplayer should do the job just fine.
- The StarOffice free version does not come bundled with e-mail. While installing it detects and integrates easily into your current default mail client—whether it's Outlook, Outlook Express or Netscape mail.
- If you're new to StarOffice and find it unfamiliar, just use context menus to figure out basic commands.
- Click on the Insert icon at the top of the main toolbar (the one that runs down your work area) to work faster.
- The Navigator is a neat tool that displays all the objects in a document. Use the Navigator (the [F5] key) to jump directly between pages, different headings, notes or hyperlinks within a document.
- To quickly open a file without using the file menu, type in the path of the file in the URL bar.
- You can directly copy drawings in StarOffice from text, spreadsheet or presentation files. All you need is [Ctrl] + [C] and [Ctrl] + [V].

Options. Under the Text document heading, select Tables. Formatting a table is simple—just select the entire table and click on Format > Autoformat.

Frames don't mean the same thing as in Word. Here a frame is like a box that may contain text. Insert > Frames gives you the option to determine size, position and format the frame and text within it.

Making 'Impress'ive presentations

Need to create snazzy presentations that will floor the clients and clinch the deal? Star Impress can do the job just as well as its Office counterpart, PowerPoint.

For simple presentations, use a slide template or customise it using Autopilot. Autopilot will run you through the process of selecting your background, slide transition, slide duration and output medium such as overhead screen or paper, in just a couple of steps.

If you want to start out with a blank slide, Impress still shows you options for slide layouts, rather like PowerPoint. Choose the appropriate layout according to what you want to display—text, images, animation, charts or diagrams. Slide background options are few but they look good. You can also add your own background through Format > Area through the colour palette or insert your own slide background (Impress supports the most popularly used image file formats).

You can also add text boxes, resize them and fill in text. The same text and paragraph format options used in Writer apply here. Use the Insert menu to insert spreadsheets, charts, diagrams and images.

While creating a slide, you might constantly need to modify the slide layout, insert a new slide or perhaps duplicate slides. Instead of having to go to the menu several times, use the floating window that has all these functions. Slide view options are located towards the top right corner of the screen within easy reach so you can change slide views constantly.

Format > Font Work lets you play around with font effects—apply shadows rather like 'Word Art' in Word. You can rotate the font, change the angle or set it to curve in different directions. With Format > 3D Effects you can add 3D effects to the font selected, such as shading illumination, geometry, textures and material.

Files created in Impress can be saved as PowerPoint or StarDraw from File > Save As. If you want to save the slide as an HTML file, you'll need to select File > Export. This opens up an Autopilot dialogue, which takes you through converting and formatting the slide as a Web page. Use Insert > File to import an HTML page.

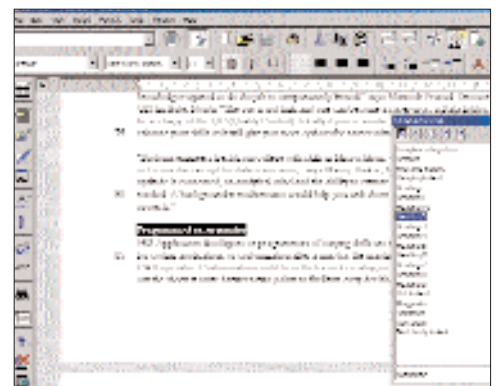
The slide show menu has all the animation, slide transition options and settings to help make your presentation more interactive. A simple way

to apply this is to select the textbox and click on Effects or Interaction. Impress also has custom slide show options.

In addition to this, you can hide slides without deleting them through Show > Hide Slide.

You'll miss the Slide Sorter feature in PowerPoint to view thumbnails of all the slides, with drag-and-drop to change slide order. StarOffice has an alternative—each slide is laid out like worksheets in spreadsheet applications like Star Calc and Excel. You can rename each slide or drag to change the slide order.

Impress handles organisation charts and flow charts pretty well. You can create them with text boxes and connectors from the Draw toolbar. The connectors move along with the boxes and hence managing them and moving the boxes around isn't difficult.



The 'Stylist' makes formatting text a breeze

Spreadsheets

Star Calc is the spreadsheet application from the StarOffice family. The worksheet and workbook options work the same as Word as do basic file functions. Calc can import external data (Import > External Data) and save files created in Calc as Excel, dBase, CSV and Lotus 123 files.

Formatting functions include formatting worksheets, rows and columns and cells. The context menu is the easiest to use for inserting, renaming and deleting sheets or setting width or height attributes to rows and cells. Format > Cells takes care of the fonts, font effects, worksheet protection, cell border and background options and merging cells.

The delete option in Calc doesn't just delete the cell content. It pulls up a dialog box which lets you select what aspect of the cell you want to delete—format, formulae, or just the text.

You can customise the Autofill option in Calc as well as use and create your own sort lists to sort data alphabetically or as per your preference through Tools > Options under the Spreadsheet category. Calc also has options to group and outline cells in the Data menu.

Calc has Filters and advanced filtering